THE GREAT NORTHERN WAR

DYNEKILEN



Date July 8, 1716
Forces Danish-Norwegians: 2 prams, 2 frigates, 3 galleys; Swedish: 1 pram, 4 galleys, 10 other armed boats
Losses Danish-Norwegians: none; Swedish: 1 pram, 3 galleys, 5 other armed boats, 19 transports captured

Location Dynekilen Fjord, western Sweden

King Charles XII of Sweden invaded Norway in 1716, besieging the citadel of Frederikstad. A squadron of Danish-Norwegian ships of the line in the Kattegat was unable to prevent the Swedish ferrying men and supplies from Gothenburg to their army, as transports and their escorts hugged the coast where the water was too shallow for the big sailing ships. Peter Tordenskjöld was sent from Copenhagen with a flotilla of Norwegian-crewed, shallow-draft vessels to break the Swedish supply line. On his way Tordenskjöld learned that a Swedish convoy was sheltering in Dynekilen fjord. He entered the narrow fjord on the morning of July 8 and found the Swedish sheltering under the protection of the 12-pounder guns of an island fort. Tordenskjöld's flotilla anchored and opened fire at around 7.30 a.m. After a lengthy exchange the fort was captured in the early afternoon. The Swedish pram *Stenbock* surrendered and the crews of her accompanying galleys fled. As Tordenskjöld secured his prizes he came under heavy fire from Swedish land forces. He made his escape late in the evening and anchored next day off Frederikstad. Sweden soon abandoned the siege and the invasion.

1691–1720

PETER TORDENSKJÖLD

DANISH NAVAL COMMANDER



Born Peter Wessel in Trondheim, Norway, Tordenskjold ran away to sea as a boy and was a merchant seaman and privateer before becoming an officer in the Danish navy in 1711. He attracted the favour of Danish King Frederick IV through the boldness of his attacks on Swedish shipping, although his unorthodox style alienated his conservative naval superiors. He was ennobled with the title Tordenskjöld ("thundershield") shortly before his great victory at Dynekilen in 1716. His capture of the Swedish fortress at Marstrand in 1718 was another notable feat. He was killed in a duel with a Livonian colonel he had accused of cheating at cards.

THE GREAT NORTHERN WAR

GRENGAM



Date August 7, 1720
Forces Swedish: 2 ships of the line, 6 frigates, 10 other vessels; Russians: 61 galleys, 25 other vessels
Losses Swedish: 4 frigates captured; Russians: 43 galleys

Location Åland Islands, Baltic Sea

The newly built Russian deep-sea sailing fleet recorded its first victory at Ezel on May 24, 1719, when it captured three Swedish warships. The galley fleet, however, continued to play a leading role in Russia's Baltic war.

In summer 1720 General Mikhail Golitsyn was commanding a large force of galleys in operations around the Åland Islands. Admiral Karl Wachtmeister, the Swedish commander-in-chief, sent a squadron under Erik Sjoblad to the islands with orders to cover the withdrawal of Swedish ships from the area. However, Sjobald chose instead to attack Golitsyn's galleys near Grengam Island. Confronted by Swedish ships of the line and frigates, the galleys hastily withdrew toward the shallow waters of Flisesund. There they formed up in line abreast and turned to face their pursuers. The Swedish cannon inflicted heavy damage on the Russian galley fleet but, maneuvering in the treacherous sound, two of the Swedish frigates soon ran aground. Russian galleys swarmed around the grounded ships and boarded them. Two other Swedish frigates were also chased and captured as the Russians took the offensive. Sjoblad's flagship, the 52-gun *Pommern*, had a narrow escape, saved only by the outstanding seamanship of its crew.

More than two-thirds of the Russian galleys were so badly damaged they had to be scuttled, leading Sweden to claim victory in the battle. However, there was no question that the Swedish had been put to flight, leaving Golitsyn in possession of the four frigates as prizes. The balance of casualties was also in Russia's favor, with the Swedish losing 103 men killed and 407 captured, compared with the Russians' 82 killed and 236 wounded.



Triumphal medallion
The capture of the Swedish frigates is commemorated on this wooden medallion from the workshops of Peter the Great.

Moment of victory
The battle of Grengam ended with the Swedish sailing ships overwhelmed by the sheer numbers of Russian galleys.

